

Pedestrian Advisory Committee Meeting Minutes

June 18, 2021 7 p.m. Remote via Zoom

Members Present: David Trevvett (Chair), Anita Johnson, Janice Morris, John Shreffler, Kerri Ann Tester, Marissa Vogt

Others Present: Abby Swaine

Members Absent: Marianne Lee

1. Public Comment Period for Issues Not on the Agenda

There was no public comment.

2. Review and Approval of Minutes of May 14, 2021 Meeting

The committee voted to approve the minutes from the May 14, 2021 meeting as distributed, with those in attendance in favor (Trevvett, Johnson, Morris, Shreffler, Tester and Vogt).

3. Recommendations to Transportation Board on Whether the Current Automatic Activation of Walk Signals Should End or be Continued. Discussion and vote on draft memo to Transportation Board

[Anita Johnson joined the meeting during this discussion]. David Trevvett led the discussion. To set the table before diving into the recommendations, David explained walk-signal recall. When a traffic signal is on recall, the walk-signal comes on automatically during every cycle. Other important terminology that was explained was exclusive (all vehicles have a red light when the walk signal is on) and concurrent (vehicular and pedestrian traffic are moving in the same direction).

Before reviewing the recommendations, John suggested that the recommendations be differentiated by geography and pedestrian density - South Brookline from North Brookline. There was agreement that pedestrian dense areas should be treated differently from those areas with less pedestrian traffic. The Committee spent time debating what that divisions should be. Geographic divisions will be included in the memo to the Transportation Board. The Transportation Board will likely refine the geographies as they deem appropriate.

Abby Swaine inquired as to the intersection of Boylston and Cyprus, and why it wasn't addressed in the memo. It was explained that Mass DOT is responsible for Route 9/Boylston St and that it wasn't in the Committee's jurisdiction. Abby said there is a Boylston St. Corridor re-imagining effort taking place and by participating in the effort, she hopes to exert some influence. This was viewed positively by all.

The Pedestrian Advisory Committee's memo will go beyond addressing whether signals should or should not be on recall. Walk signals should make sense and facilitate the safe and appropriate movement of pedestrians. Today there are signals that do not make sense and should be re-examined. We hope that the entirety of our recommendations will be considered by the Transportation Board in future months.

Review of recommendations:

- Walk signals in the far south areas of Brookline should be on exclusive programming and not be on recall. All members supported this recommendation.
- For walk signals on concurrent programming, where pedestrian movement is parallel with the traffic that has the green light, these signals should be kept on recall, e.g., Beacon Street. All members supported this recommendation.
- Discussion of a new idea: To make a traffic signal be both exclusive and concurrent for certain intersections. David shared an example of Harvard and Fuller, where pedestrians have a short exclusive but then are told not to walk across Fuller during the 60 seconds when parallel traffic moves along Harvard. Pedestrians wanting to cross Fuller aren't waiting and are crossing Fuller against the "Don't Walk" (so concurrent with Harvard vehicular traffic). The idea is to explore having the walk signals for crossing Fuller be concurrent with the Harvard vehicle green light, then have a short exclusive signal to help pedestrians cross Harvard itself. This approach could be appropriate at a few intersections, particularly T intersections, like Beacon and Fairbanks.
- Discussion of complex intersections: There are several complex intersections, like Washington, Cyprus and School Street, that need special consideration and programming. Washington, Harvard and Kent is another complex intersection but cannot be addressed until the crushed conduit is fixed. Until that is addressed, pedestrians lack a walk signal to help them cross Davis safely. These complex cases should be dealt with on a case by case basis.
- Answering the question asked by the Transportation Board: The Committee was asked whether recall should be removed - yes or no. Our response would propose differentiation by geographic area and pedestrian density. Denser areas like Coolidge Corner and Emerson Gardens/Pill Hill should remain on recall. Further northwest and south, no recall, reverting to pedestrian activated. A question had been previously raised by the Transportation Board regarding confusion as to where/when the pedestrian needs to push the button (or not). By having clear geographies and consistent treatments within those areas, we would hope that there would be less confusion.
- A question was asked by Anita and Kerri Ann: can recall be tailored to time of day? The members felt that would make sense if it could be.
- Denser housing areas which currently have exclusive programming should also be kept on recall.

The Committee authorized David to write the memo with the assistance of a few committee members. Marissa, John and Kerri volunteered to assist. David planned to submit the final memo to the Transportation Board on Jun 19. The memo will reflect the committee discussion and recommendations. All voted in favor (Trevvett, Johnson, Morris, Shreffler, Tester, Vogt).

4. Brookline's Sidewalk Winter Snow Removal - Discussion of updated draft memo to Transportation Board

David noted that an earlier version of the memo was sent to Erin Gallentine and Kevin Johnson in case they wanted to provide input/feedback. To date, he had not heard back. The version that is being discussed reflects comments from Abby Swaine.

The Committee is sharing these recommendations with the Transportation Board seeking their assistance in communicating to the appropriate town departments. The timing feels appropriate as a revision of the snow and ice management plan is currently underway.

The recommendations include:

- Expand number of sidewalks cleared by the town
- Town should clear cross-street curb ramps and they should remain clear
- Clarify DPW's responsibility for clearing bus stops not cleared by the MBTA
- Support the Town in developing or supporting programs that assist residents in complying with the snow removal if compliance otherwise presents an undue burden.
- Update the by-laws:
 - decrease the time period, following a storm's end for the clearance of the sidewalk
 - increase the fines
 - levy the fines on a per-day basis.
 - assess larger fines for residences or businesses with exceptionally large frontages
- Enhance the Town's ability to enforce snow removal compliance by empowering additional town staff. This recommendation is reinforced by Cambridge's practices.
- Increase public awareness that trash, recycling, compost containers may not be placed within the required snow cleared width of sidewalks.

The Committee agreed the memo and the recommendations were final. David was authorized to incorporate discussed changes to the memo and submit it. The vote was taken and all were in favor (Trevvett, Johnson, Morris, Shreffler, Tester, Vogt) . Marissa was recognized for her excellent work, particularly in compiling the data.

5. Encroaching Hedges Project: Discussion of draft report and next steps

David has been working on the report and memo. The goals of the report, relative to The Transportation Board, are to establish that there has been an issue of encroaching hedges, which is supported with documentation, and to recommend changes. It will explain:

- Why it's been challenging for the town to deal with
- Identify and share improvements that DPW has made in recent months that seem to be having an impact.
- To establish the need for a change in the town by-laws
- Identify specific actions that we want the Transportation Board and the Town (DPW) to take.

Other discussion as to what should be included in the memo:

- Central repository that is public facing:
Anita also suggested that there be a consistent way to capture all customer complaints centrally, whether BrookOnline, email, phone call. Possibly use BrookOnline as the central repository. It may be possible to enhance the linkage with the DPW's work order system. It also should be clear as to what action has been taken and what the status is. This will allow for better tracking and ultimate resolution and one that is public-facing. Abby Swaine stressed the importance that emails or BrookOnline handicap accessibility issues are also properly captured and reported without considerable rework. David stated that it is likely they are captured in the work order system, we need to ensure that there is a public view of those requests.
- Sidewalk trees and hedges maintained by the Town:
Marissa raised the benefits and issues associated with sidewalk trees that are the responsibility of the town. There are situations where sidewalks are obstructed with overhanging branches or trees that take up the majority of the sidewalk. David commented that similar themes will be brought forward in the pedestrian lighting report.

David agreed that the memo will address these additional issues. He asked that the members review the draft and be prepared to finalize it at the July meeting.

6. Discussion of other groups/activities since the May meeting, kindling Boylston Street Study Committee public forums, Disparity Working Group and Pedestrian-Friendly Lighting Committee

There were no updates.

7. Committee Housekeeping

The next scheduled meeting is July 14. Typically the Committee takes the month of August off, but September has a number of Jewish holidays and we typically try to avoid all religious holidays. The September calendar may influence whether there is an August meeting. This topic will be on the July meeting agenda.

8. New business

Abby Swaine brought up a need for some of us to begin working with Erin Gallentine to develop a warrant article for amending the by-law that speaks to sidewalk obstructions in the public way. The focus would be to modernize and better enumerate the types of obstructions – including encroaching hedges and other vegetation -- and to specify penalties. It will require working with Town Counsel, Erin Gallentine and other interested parties and committees, and would need to start soon to meet the deadline for the fall Town Meeting. Some thought that the warrant would open by mid-August, and any warrant article would need to be submitted before the end of September. This Committee cannot lead this effort but Anita and one or two others, acting as independent Brookline residents, could work with Abby and the others. The next step was for Abby to contact Erin to arrange a group meeting so that those working on the warrant article could get her input and understand her expectations.

Minutes prepared by: Janice Morris